Vasu Ghosha

Васу Гхош · @vasu-ghosha

The Singer of Gaura

Vasudeva Ghosha Thakura — in songs and in the lists of Vaishnavas he is simply called Vasu Ghosha — is one of Sri Gauranga's eternal companions. He signed his own padas in both ways: the last line of a song says now "so says Vasu," now "so says Vasudeva Ghosha." Just as Gaudiya Vaishnavas always sing of Narahari Sarakara Thakura together with the name, form, qualities and pastimes of Gaurasundara, so they glorify Vasudeva as an eternal companion in Gaura-lila.

Vasu Ghosha stands beside the Lord in the evening worship as well. In Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura's “Gaura-arati” Narahari and others fan Gaurachandra with chamaras, while Sanjaya, Mukunda, Vasu Ghosha and others sing. Thus the poet has kept Vasu forever in his place — among the singers surrounding the Lord.

The Three Ghosha Brothers

Vasudeva was born into a kayastha family of northern Rarh — Uttara-Rarhi, the part of Rarh through which the Ganga does not flow. The family was respected and prominent. Vasudeva had two brothers: Govinda Ghosha and Madhava Ghosha, who is also called Madhavananda. Which of the three was the eldest the biographies do not say; Kavi Karnapura in the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” names them in this order: Govinda, Madhavananda, Vasudeva.

The family is linked with Shrihatta (Sylhet) through the village of Buran, or Burangi: according to one account, the house of Vasudeva's maternal uncle stood there[1]. His father, whose name the biographies do not give, for some reason settled in Kumarahatta, and later the three brothers moved from there to Navadvipa[2]. Neither the year nor the place of Vasudeva's birth, nor the day of his appearance, is given in the biographies.

Krishnadasa Kaviraja in the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” calls the three brothers branches of Sri Chaitanya's tree[3], and first of all he recalls their singing — the very thing for which they were loved:

“Three brothers — Govinda, Madhava and Vasudeva. When they sang kirtana in self-forgetfulness, Sri Chaitanya and Nityananda danced.” (CC, Adi 10.115)

Listing Nityananda's companions later on, Kaviraja Gosvami says that some of them are counted in two communities at once — among the devotees of Sri Chaitanya and among the devotees of Nityananda. Such are Abhirama Thakura and Gadadhara Dasa, and such are two of the brothers as well:

“Madhava and Vasudeva Ghosha also belonged to both these groups.” (CC, Adi 11.15)

Govinda, who stayed with the Lord, the biographies count among the branches of Sri Chaitanya alone; of Vasudeva no such remark is made: his place is in both ganas.

Gunatunga

Kavi Karnapura reveals who the three brothers were in Krishna's eternal pastimes:

“Kalavati, Rasollasa and Gunatunga, who were in Vraja and sang the songs composed by Sri Vishakha, are now considered to be Govinda, Madhavananda and Vasudeva respectively.” (GGD 188)

Vasudeva, then, is in Vraja the sakhi Gunatunga, one of the singers who sang the songs composed by Sri Vishakha.

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati Thakura in the “Gaudiya-bhashya” opens this further: Madhava, Vasudeva and Govinda are kaya-vyuha, personal expansions of the ashraya-vigraha of the madhura-rasa of Vraja, that is, of Sri Radha. Ashraya means "shelter," the "abode" of love: she in whose heart love for Krishna reaches its summit, while Krishna Himself is its object, the vishaya. The brothers therefore serve in madhura-rasa as intimates of Srimati Radhika, who have accepted Her as the highest shelter of that love.

With Nityananda in Bengal

When Mahaprabhu settled in Puri, He sent Nityananda to preach in Gauda, Bengal. Two of the brothers went with Him; the third stayed with the Lord:

“By the direct order of Sri Chaitanya, Nityananda Prabhu set out for Bengal together with three devotees. These three devotees were named Ramadasa, Madhava and Vasudeva Ghosha. Govinda Ghosha, however, remained with Sri Chaitanya, and was exceedingly glad of it.” (CC, Adi 10.117–118)

In Bengal Nityananda danced and the brothers sang. Vrindavana Dasa Thakura in the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” singles out Madhava:

“The pious Madhava Ghosha was the most skilled in singing kirtana. In this he had no equal in all the world. He was known as the singer of the Lord's pastimes in Vrindavana, and he was very dear to Lord Nityananda. The three brothers — Madhava, Vasudeva and Govinda — sang while Lord Nityananda danced.” (CB, Antya 5.257–259)

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati Thakura, in the “Gaudiya-bhashya” on this verse, calls all three brothers "singers of Vrindavana"[4]. Their singing had nothing in common with that of worldly performers: the brothers were wholly given to kirtana, and they had no worldly notions. Here lies the meaning of the name: the desire to serve Hari grows in the heart only when worldly conceptions have been destroyed completely.

In Panihati Nityananda came to the house of Raghava Pandita together with the three Ghosha brothers. When they began to sing, He broke into dance with a thunderous roar, and afterwards sat on a raised seat and ordered Raghava to perform His abhisheka[5].

All the while the brothers were in Gauda, Vasu Ghosha and Madhava served Nityananda with their singing: He danced, they led the kirtana. The brothers remain inseparable in the memory of the Vaishnavas, too: Madhavananda Ghosha, who sang the “Dana-khanda” before Nityananda in the temple of Gadadhara Dasa, is called by one biography simply "the brother of Vasudeva Ghosha."

In Puri, at the Ratha-yatra

Every year Vasudeva and his brothers walked from Gauda to Nilachala — together with Shivananda Sena and the other devotees of Bengal — and came for the Ratha-yatra. There their famous kirtana increased the Lord's joy. The “Chaitanya-charitamrita” speaks of the third year of these journeys:

“With their travelling bags, Acharyaratna, Vidyanidhi, Shrivasa, Ramai, Vasudeva, Murari Gupta, Raghava Pandita and Govinda with his two brothers set out on the road. The residents of Kulinagrama joined them too, bringing new silken ropes.” (CC, Madhya 16.16)

At the Ratha-yatra Mahaprabhu divided the singers into seven groups. The Ghosha brothers sang in the fourth:

“The Lord formed the fourth group, headed by the kirtaniya Govinda Ghosha. Junior Haridasa, Vishnudasa and Raghava were to sing the responses with him in the kirtana, as well as the two brothers — Madhava and Vasudeva Ghosha. Vakreshvara Pandita was chosen as the dancer.” (CC, Madhya

13.42–43)

Before Jagannatha's chariot Vasudeva sang together with his brothers, and Vakreshvara Pandita himself danced before them[6].

Songs

All three brothers composed padas and sang with sweet voices. But as a poet Vasudeva is better known than his brothers: many of his songs have survived, while of Govinda's and Madhava's only a few remain.

Vasudeva began to compose songs about Gauranga following Narahari Sarakara Thakura. The “Padasamudra” tells that, having drunk deep of the nectar of Sarakara Thakura's songs, he himself longed to express that nectar in verse; it also sings the wondrous glory of Narahari — Madhumati of Vraja, whose virtues have no end (in almost the same words the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” 2.220, speaks of Narahari).

All of Vasudeva's genuine songs are about Sri Gaura. They are very simple, full of sweetness, and touch the depths of the heart. Not without reason did Krishnadasa Kaviraja say of him:

“When Vasudeva Ghosha sang kirtana glorifying Sri Chaitanya and Nityananda, at the sound of his voice even wood and stone would sometimes melt.” (CC, Adi 11.19)

Vasu paints the Lord's childhood as if he himself were standing in Shachi's courtyard. Little Vishvambhara plays hide-and-seek with His mother[7]:

"In Shachi's courtyard Vishvambhara Raya dances; laughing, turning about, He hides from His mother. Covering His face with His cloth, He says: 'I have hidden!' Shachi says: 'Vishvambhara, I cannot see You!' Holding the end of His mother's sari, on restless little feet He goes skipping with the gait of a wagtail. Says Vasudeva Ghosha: 'A wondrous beauty! Seeing the form of the Child, the world is filled with longing.'" (Vasu Ghosha, PK 1151)

In another song Vasu glorifies Gaura as Jagannatha and Krishna Himself:

"Glory, glory to Jagannatha, the son of Shachi, whose feet the three worlds worship! In Nilachala He holds the conch, disc, club and lotus, in the town of Nadia — the staff and water pot in His hands. Some say that formerly He slew Ravana; He manifested the splendour of the pastimes of Goloka. And now, in the mood of Sri Radha, He is the Gora-avatara: Gaura has preached the name 'Hare Krishna.' Vasudeva Ghosha says with folded palms: He is Gaura, He is Krishna, He is Jagannatha." (Vasu Ghosha, PK 2192)

One of the biographies explains the song thus: Rama, who punished Ravana, is one of His manifestations; from Goloka He descends as Gaura, in the mood of Radharani, and He is one with Rama, Krishna and Jagannatha. Two lines of this song — of Gaura the sannyasi "with staff and water pot" and of Gaura who came "in the mood of Sri Radha" — utterly refute the doctrines of the nadiya-nagari and gaura-nagari, which picture Gaura as a nagara, a lover of the women of Nadia. In Vasu Gaura is a sannyasi who has come in the mood of Sri Radha, His eternal beloved; such a Gaura has no place in the fancies of the nagaris.

Another song begins: "What shall I say of Your hundreds and hundreds of incarnations? Gaurangachand alone is my life." In the incarnation of Vishnu the Lord is a beggar asking for prema, with Shiva, Shuka and Narada beside Him; in the incarnation of Rama He built the bridge across the ocean to Lanka; and now, in the age of Kali, His kirtana has become the bridge:

"In the age of Kali You made kirtana the bridge: let all the lame, the dull and the blind cross over with ease. By what qualities do men dance, by what qualities women? By Gora's qualities the fourteen worlds are intoxicated. I know neither japa, nor austerity, nor this Vedic reasoning. Says Vasu: 'Gauranga, carry me across!'" (Vasu Ghosha, PK 2292)[8]

Vasu has also left a song about Nityananda, in raga sindhura. Nitai is the only friend of the fallen: by the living beings' age-old merits Providence brought Him to them, like an ocean of jewels to the destitute. Then the poet describes Nityananda in separation from Gaura:

"Looking all around, He goes and calls, 'Lord Gora Raya!' — and falls unconscious to the ground. His dear companions gather, take Nitai in their arms and weep, gazing at His moonlike face. His eyes, red as a fresh lotus, brim with tears of prema — as if the Mandakini were streaming down Sumeru. With a voice deep as the thunder of clouds He calls, 'Brother, brother!' — under the weight of His steps the earth trembles. Merciful Nitai gave the living beings the shelter of prema — such mercy is known to all the world. Through the sankirtana of the name so dear to Him He delivered the people of the world — why then has Vasu been left out?" (Vasu Ghosha, PK 2314)

One of the best known songs linked with Vasu's name begins "had Gaura not come…":

"Had there been no Gauranga, what would have become of us? How would we have lived? The glory of Radha, the summit of the rasa of prema — who would have made it known to the world?" (Vasu Ghosha, PK 2345)[9]

Srila B. R. Sridhar Maharaj (Bhakti Rakshak Sridhar Dev-Goswami) explained the meaning of this song thus. Gauranga revealed to us the very essence of life, its charm — divine love. Without Him we would not know that in the world of this love Radharani stands above all, and life would be impossible. Only having received this from Him do we see that life is worth living.

Vasudeva's songs are honoured also as a testimony to the secrets of Gaura-lila. Thus, that Gadadhara Pandita is Srimati Radharani in Vraja is confirmed, it is said, by the notes of Svarupa Damodara and the songs of Vasudeva Ghosha.

The Genuine Vasu and Songs Not His

In time much that is foreign was mixed into the collection of Vasudeva's songs. Into his padavali many gaura-nagari songs have been inserted — songs that gratify the senses of the prakrita-sahajiyas and portray Gaura as a worldly lover of the women of Nadia. They cannot be the songs of Srila Vasudeva: Vasudeva is a devotee of Gaura who relishes the rasa of separation (vipralambha-rasika). Pure devotees must carefully reject such songs.

The genuine Vasu is recognized at once: he sings of separation, he sees in Gaura Krishna Himself in Radha's mood and Gaura the sannyasi. The gaura-nagari songs ascribed to him pure devotees reject.

Last Years and Departure

Of Vasudeva's later years the information is scanty and divergent. It is said that after the Lord's sannyasa, pained by separation from Him, the brothers parted: Madhava settled in Daihata, and Vasudeva in Tamoluk (Tamluk, in Midnapore); his shripat was there[10].

Vasudeva Ghosha departed on shukla-dvitiya — the second lunar day of the bright fortnight — of the month of Damodara (Kartika). On this day he is also remembered by the Vaishnava calendar of Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math. The year and place of his departure, like the place of his samadhi, are not given in the biographies.

Yet even after the departure of Mahaprabhu and His companions the Ghosha brothers did not leave the kirtana. According to the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (10.572 ff.), when Narottama Dasa sang at the great festival in Kheturi, Sri Chaitanya appeared there with His companions, and among them were Madhava Ghosha, Vasu Ghosha and Govinda Ghosha.

Significance

Vasu Ghosha is an eternal companion of Gaura, the sakhi Gunatunga of Sri Radha's circle, the singer to whose voice Sri Chaitanya and Nityananda danced. His songs, simple and heartfelt, have remained living kirtana in the Gaudiya Vaishnava tradition: in them Gaura is Krishna Himself, come in the feeling of Radha, and the great renunciant; there is nothing worldly in them, for they were composed by one who had tasted the rasa of separation. And so the poet himself, pleading "Gauranga, carry me across!" and grieving "why then has Vasu been left out?", teaches us the humility without which one cannot sing the glories of the Lord.

1. According to other information, Baduna, or Burangi, in Shrihatta was the brothers' native village.

2. According to one biography, the brothers moved to Navadvipa after their father's death.

3. According to one biography, the brothers are the eighty-second, eighty-third and eighty-fourth branches; in the subheadings of our translation of the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” the numbering is different (Govinda Ghosha is the eighty-first branch, and the eighty-fourth is Abhirama Thakura).

4. In the verse of the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” itself it is Madhava Ghosha who is called "the singer of Vrindavana"; the name is applied to all three brothers by Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's commentary, and after it by one of the biographies (which gives these words as its own).

5. According to another account, Nityananda danced in trance to the brothers' singing, then sat on the Deities' throne, and abhisheka was performed for Him.

6. According to the “Chaitanya-charitamrita,” the lead singer of the fourth group was Govinda Ghosha, while Vasudeva and Madhava sang the responses; so too most of the biographies. One of them, in its chapter on Vasudeva, names Vasudeva "with his two brothers" as the lead singers.

7. One of the biographies, quoting this pada, specifies the place: the courtyard of Shachi and Jagannatha in Mayapur. These are the biographer's own words: the text of the pada he quotes has only "Shachi's courtyard."

8. In the retelling of one biography the song sounds different: all the incarnations of Vishnu, Shiva, Shukadeva, Narada, the four Kumaras and the lords of the universe beg for the love that Gauranga alone distributes; all men and women, without any qualification, dance and attain perfection; His qualities have maddened "the ten directions"; and the ending there is an appeal to others: give up japa, austerity and Vedic knowledge and accept Gauranga with all your soul.

9. The first line is known in several versions ("Had Gaura not come, what would have been then?"). In one old collection this pada bears the signature of Narahari.

10. The accounts diverge. According to one (with the reservation "some say" and a mark of doubt), Vasudeva settled in Tamoluk after the Lord's sannyasa, pained by separation from Him; elsewhere in the same book Tamoluk is called his shripat without reservation; according to another biography, he "in the end" settled in Tamoluk; according to a third, the brothers parted after Mahaprabhu's departure, and Vasudeva settled in the village of Tamala.